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How Do I Come Back After a Career Break?

by Robert Chess

RICHARD CARTER PICKED up a framed photo from his desk as he waited for the videoconference to connect. In the picture his daughter, Ava, was seven years old—eyes bright, hair wild, clutching an oversized butterfly net in their backyard. He had taken it a decade ago during their first week of home-schooling, just after he'd left his job as a divisional vice president of marketing at a major consumer-goods company to teach her himself.

Ava was brilliant but, owing to her Level 1 autism spectrum disorder, had

been misunderstood by the faculty and staff of mainstream schools. Recognizing a bit of himself in her, Richard had refused to let her repeat his lonely childhood. So he stepped off the corporate track entirely and built her a custom education from scratch.

The daughter and father had succeeded. At 17 Ava moved into her Stanford dorm while Richard and his wife, Annie, stood by the rental SUV, holding a box fan and a bag of Trader Joe's snacks. Ava hugged them hard, waved once, and walked into her future.



The silence that followed was cavernous.

For a while Richard told people he was retired, but the words always caught in his throat. A lecture he attended at the university downtown on the dangers of retirement passivity hit him harder than expected. The professor warned that the “walk on the beach every day fantasy” was less paradise and more slow erasure. “Purpose is oxygen,” she’d said.

On his 52nd birthday Richard told Annie he wanted to go back to work. Not because they needed the money—her medical practice was steady—but because he needed to feel useful again. That’s why he now sat staring at his laptop, waiting for the Zoom chime.

The person who appeared was older, grayer, but familiar: Mark Ellison, the Spencer Stuart partner who’d once slid Richard’s résumé to the top of a stack.

“Richard! It’s been forever.”

They fell into a warm conversation, catching up on kids, their shared love of travel, and the general passage of time. Then came the shift.

“Listen,” Mark said, leaning back. “You were a star, no question. But a decade is a long gap. My clients are really focused on currency right now. They want people who’ve been operating recently and understand how the latest AI tools can impact their businesses. I could try to ask around, but...”

Richard said he understood and moved the conversation back to safer



ground, inquiring about Mark’s eldest, who was graduating from college soon.

After the meeting it didn’t take long for Annie to appear in the doorway.

“How was the call?”

“Good,” Richard said. “Productive. Gave me some avenues to explore.”

“Any roles he thought were a fit?”

“We...talked big-picture strategy,” he murmured, surprised to feel embarrassed in front of the wife who had always believed in him.

THE EXPERIENCED OLD GUY

Richard hit his network hard, and seven weeks of phone calls and emails later, he found himself in an open-plan expanse of standing desks, cold brew stations, and ambition. A neon sign on a wall read “Ship > Perfect.”

He was scheduled to meet Evan Torres, the 31-year-old CEO of NeuroLark, a Series B startup building an AI-powered

wellness app for neurodiverse teens. He’d landed the meeting through David Kim, a former MBA classmate and the company’s lead investor. David had sent a generous email to the team about Richard’s strategic instincts and his experience parenting a daughter in the app’s target demographic.

“Let’s dive,” Evan said, his laptop open and hoodie sleeves pushed up. “What’s something you accomplished in your last role that you’re proud of?”

Richard straightened, relieved to start somewhere familiar. “I led the national rollout of a home-care brand campaign we called Trusted Home, Trusted Care. We built the brand architecture from the ground up—values, tone, messaging—and tied it to a multiyear media plan. At the time it was considered cutting-edge because we used household penetration analytics to drive product placement in retail chains. Nielsen called it a top performer that year.”



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He stopped, realizing that he had just described a world of TV spots, circulars, and end-cap displays—ancient history to the person in front of him.

Evan nodded politely. “Cool. Totally. Today our growth is driven by loops, not campaigns. We acquire users through TikTok microinfluencers, onboard them with a frictionless routine builder, and retain them via community neuro-coaching prompts. The goal is compounding network effects.”

Richard fidgeted in his chair. “So... trust is still central,” he replied. “You still need emotional resonance to—”

“Sure,” Evan said. “But the engine is the product. Not the messaging.” He turned his laptop to show Richard a graphic filled with colorful funnels and arrows. “How would you optimize our user activation flow?”

Richard took a breath. “First I’d define the strategic pillars of brand trust—” he began, seeing the comment was already landing wrong. “But I’d also want to learn how *you* analyze engagement here—shadow the product team, understand what signals matter most, then build experiments from there.”

Evan nodded. “OK. How are you with data tooling? SAS? Even just doing regression modeling in Sheets?”

“I can manage spreadsheets,” Richard said carefully. “But for complex things I’d probably require some training and maybe the help of an LLM tool, which I know many coders are using.”

Evan nodded again, closing his laptop. “I like your experience. And I get the personal connection to our mission. But we move at startup speed. People learn by doing—fast. Are you sure that’s the pace you want to operate at?”

“Absolutely,” Richard said. “I’ve found success in a variety of environments. I’m ready for the next challenge.”

As he drove home, Richard replayed the meeting in his head. He had been a step behind at first but was able to think on his feet. He remembered the thrill of stepping up under pressure, and a thought popped into his head: *That kid talks a big game, but I could run rings around him.*

His daydreaming was interrupted by a call from Annie. “How did it go?”

“Fine,” he said.

She waited. “Only fine?”

“It’s just...” He exhaled. “It’s strange being the old guy trying to get someone half my age to hire me.”

STARTING OVER, LOWER DOWN

A few days later Richard stood by the window of his home office, staring out at the oak tree he had once turned into a makeshift biology lab for Ava. After another round of meetings with Evan and his team, he was waiting to hear back from NeuroLark. Annie entered with a mug of tea and her computer.

“You seem a little stuck,” she said, handing him the tea.

He didn’t argue. “I feel irrelevant. Like the world moved on while I was doing something that mattered, and now it doesn’t matter to anyone else.”

Annie sat on the arm of the chair and opened her laptop. “I found something,” she said. “A returnship program at a *Fortune* 100 company. Structured training, intentional support, and look—a 70% conversion rate to full-time roles.”

Richard made a face. “So I’d be a 52-year-old intern?”

“It’s not about status,” she replied. “It’s scaffolding. You’d learn the current tools, the new playbook, with other people doing the same thing.” She smiled gently. “To maintain my medical license, I sit in rooms to learn from residents 20 years younger than me. No one thinks it’s shameful. It’s how professionals stay sharp.”

Richard looked away.

“And the people who get hired out of this program?” Annie continued. “Former executives, consultants, people who stepped away for caregiving or medical reasons. You fit the pattern. You’re not an exception.”

He finally turned to meet her gaze. “Even if they hire me after the internship, it would be into a position far below where I was 15 years ago.”

“Well, I don’t know what to tell you,” she said, a hint of frustration in her voice. “You don’t have to go back into an organizational role. You could be a personal tutor. You loved teaching Ava. There are a hundred ways to be useful that don’t require chasing the job you used to have.”

He swallowed. “I want to contribute more substantially. I’d like to pay Ava’s tuition. I’d like to feel like I’m carrying some of the water.”

“I know you do,” Annie said. She placed the laptop on his desk, the program’s application open. His name was already typed into the first field. “Sleep on it,” she said.

A CHOICE FOR HIMSELF

The next week Richard texted his oldest friend, Tom Alvarez, and asked if he could come over. They had known each



other since they were teenagers piling into a beat-up Ford Escort on humid Texas nights. Tom ran a landscaping business with five employees, coached Little League, and seemed, to Richard, almost unnervingly content.

They sat at the patio table out back. Annie had left them iced tea and given them space.

"You look like you've been thinking too hard," Tom said, leaning back.

Richard slid two offer letters across the table. "I need to choose a job. And I can't tell if I'm choosing for the right reasons."

Tom skimmed the NeuroLark offer first. "VP of marketing." He whistled. "Big title."

Richard shrugged. "On a team of three. Reporting to a CEO who was in middle school when I was giving conference keynotes."

"And the pay?"

"Lower salary than I had before I stepped away. Equity makes up the difference—if the company succeeds."

"OK. And the other one?"

Richard gestured to the second letter. "Structured reentry program with the hope of being placed as a marketing

Should Richard take the job at the startup or the returnship?

THE EXPERTS RESPOND.



CAROL FISHMAN COHEN is the CEO and a cofounder of career-reentry company iRelaunch.

The returnship is a terrific opportunity for Richard to restart his career.

Such programs in *Fortune* 100 companies are highly competitive and specifically designed to provide transitional support with enhanced onboarding, mentorship, and a community of fellow returners, usually in their forties and fifties. Compensation is typically at market rates, it's prorated for the length of the returnship, and more than 85% of participants, on average, are hired when their program is over.

I like that the opportunity is tied to a real open position—in Richard's case, a marketing manager role. Returnships set up this way are built on an "intent to hire," meaning everyone—recruiters, the hiring manager, the team, and the returner—is expecting a long-term match if performance is strong. This model creates a far more meaningful onboarding experience for all involved than project-based returnships, in which participants function more like short-term contractors, with no specific role waiting for them.

If Richard is offered a permanent role but decides that working in a corporate setting is not the right fit for him, he can decide not to accept the job. There is no pressing financial need, so he will still have plenty of time to regroup.

Although I am optimistic about Richard's prospects for a full-time offer, he must still devote time to meaningful preparation. His conversation with the startup CEO was valuable in pointing Richard to a road map for updating his knowledge and skills. Once he becomes familiar with current marketing

concepts and tools—TikTok micro-influencers, user activation flows, data tooling, Sheets, and so on—he will be in a completely different place professionally. He should use the time before the returnship start date to dive deep into the current state of his industry and to aggressively refresh his skills, whether through coursework, certificates, or credentialing programs. After he begins the program, Richard can ease the pace but should continue the outside learning.

This preparation will also allow him to speak substantively about his field with teammates, former colleagues, and new contacts—a shift that will improve his integration, credibility, and capacity to network. If Richard is worried about feeling old, as he expressed following his interview with Evan, demonstrating his subject matter expertise will help take the focus off his age and the length of his career break, and keep it on the quality and relevance of his contributions.

The startup role feels like a disaster waiting to happen. Taking



“There are a hundred ways to be useful that don’t require chasing the job you used to have.”

manager. But a clear ladder back up if I do well.”

“How’s it pay?”

“Lower than I’d like, but better than NeuroLark.”

Tom linked his hands behind his head. “I know it would feel good to be able to tell people you’re a VP again, but you can’t pick a job based on that alone.”

“You’re right. So what do I do?”

“You ever notice,” Tom said after a long pause, “how Ava talks about you?”

She doesn’t say, ‘My dad used to be a VP.’ She says, ‘My dad taught me how to understand myself.’ She says you changed her life.”

Richard thought about the comment, his jaw tight. Tom slid the papers back toward his friend. He let the silence sit for a moment, and then added, “Seems to me you’re pretty lucky to have two great options, and you’ll be successful no matter which path you take.”

Richard looked at the two offers spread across the table. He felt exhilarated and a little scared by the realization that, after years defined by obligations to others, this choice was entirely his. ■



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on a fast-paced marketing job with skills from 10 years ago would be wildly stressful and likely to end badly for both Richard and NeuroLark, even if he is a quick learner. A returnship is by far the better springboard for resuming his career.



ASHLEY DARTNELL is the former global director of diversity, equity, and inclusion at Boston Consulting Group.

Richard should join the startup.

At this stage in his life and career, he shouldn’t be optimizing for salary, prestige, or even stability—he should be seeking purpose. When you’re in your fifties and you’re financially secure, the most meaningful driver of long-term satisfaction is whether your work aligns with what you value. Richard’s values are clear: He spent a decade caring and advocating for his neurodiverse daughter. NeuroLark’s mission speaks directly to his experience and passion. That kind of alignment is rare.

I’ve been in Richard’s shoes. I left full-time corporate life when my young daughter was diagnosed with Type 1 diabetes. I reentered years later, finding purpose by working on diversity, equity, and inclusion issues at a firm where most employees were two decades my junior.

While the NeuroLark job might feel risky, it’s actually relatively riskless. If it doesn’t work out—and Richard will know that in a few months—he can revert to a returnship. Those programs will still be there, offering structure and a path back to a corporate role.

Richard should join the startup with confidence because he brings tremendous assets: lived experience as a caregiver, decades of leadership and brand expertise, empathy, maturity, and the ability to manage teams and communicate in high-stakes environments. His colleagues will teach him new tools and platforms, and he will teach them judgment, resilience, and how to build an organization.

Still, his NeuroLark interview showed he’s rusty, so he needs to set himself up to succeed. That means doing informational interviews with people in the sector, understanding the norms of startup culture, reading everything he can about new technologies, and getting baseline proficiency in modern tech tools like Slack, Sheets, and gen AI.

Socially, he shouldn’t try to be one of the thirtysomethings, but he should adapt to the culture—for instance, by not showing up in a suit if his coworkers wear hoodies. The quickest and best way to find belonging is through the company’s mission. Sharing his stories

about raising a neurodiverse child will create instant credibility with colleagues who care deeply about the product’s purpose but haven’t experienced the caregiving side of it.

Finally, Richard should prepare for the impact this transition may have on his marriage and household. One of the biggest surprises people face when reentering full-time work is the shift in daily logistics and emotional expectations. Richard and Annie should talk about how routines will change—including what needs to be delegated and how to protect time for each other. Getting this right can’t be an afterthought.

The startup role will stretch Richard, humble him, and force him to learn new rhythms. But it offers what matters most at this stage: purpose, challenge, and the chance to build something that makes the world better for families like his. ■

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